

The Cubano — Full Build

Bread → marinated pork → pan reduction → build & press · one standalone system

BREAD	PORK	MARINADE	ROAST	PRESS
4 @ 360g → 8	6 lb butt	24–48 hr	275°→195°F	275–300°F

Plan-ahead: pork marinates 24–48 hr and roasts ~6–8 hr. Start the day before.	Same-day: bread is a ~4–4.5 hr same-day bake at 70°F. The finishing sauce is the pan reduction — the marinade + drippings reduced down, no separate build.
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PART 1

CUBAN BREAD

AP flour, NOT bread flour — tender, pressable

INGREDIENT	BAKER %	WEIGHT
AP flour (~10.5–11.5% protein)	100%	850 g
Water (~100g @ 100–110°F to bloom; rest room-temp ~70°F)	60%	510 g
Lard (rendered pork lard — structural)	4%	34 g
Sugar	2%	17 g
Salt	2%	17 g
ADY (bloomed)	1.5%	13 g

- 1 **Bloom ADY:** yeast + sugar in ~100g water at **100–110°F**, **5–10 min** to foam. Over ~115°F kills it.
- 2 **Mix:** flour, salt, lard, bloom, remaining water. Knead to **moderate** gluten — soft, NOT windowpane. ~8–10 min.
- 3 **Bulk:** ~1.5–2 hr to doubled at **70°F** — by the dough, not the clock.
- 4 **Shape:** 4 × 360g, ~16" loaves (full half-pan length), slim — **Jimmy John's width (~2")**, seam down. **Cut each in half after baking → 8 × 8" sandwiches.** Bake **2 per half pan** (two pans) for even spring; 3 fits snug, don't crowd 4 on one.
- 5 **Proof:** 45–60 min until puffy.
- 6 **Score** one lengthwise slash. **Bake 400°F** w/ steam first 10 min, then dry; ~20–22 min to **pale golden** (200–205°F internal). **Brush hot with lard/butter** for a soft, pressable crust.

TEMP TARGETS

this stage — the bread

Bloom water	100–110°F — foam in 5–10 min. Over ~115°F kills the yeast.
Dough temp	Final 76–78°F off the mixer — dough water room-temp (~70°F), the bloom is the warm part. Probe it.
Rise	Bulk & proof at 70°F room — by the dough, not the clock.
Bake	Oven 400°F , pull at 200–205°F internal — pale golden, NOT dark.

PART 2 · THE PORK

Marinated Pork

PART 2		MARINADE	No salt — salt the meat (see cook)	
Badia Mojo Marinade (base — garlic + onion already in it)	1,170 g	Onion sliced thin	1 large	
Olive oil or lard (held — floats in a bath)	120 g	Cracked black pepper	12 g	
Ground cumin (fresh)	20 g	Bay leaves	5	
Mexican oregano dried	10 g	Maggi seasoning (umami, rec.)	56 g	
		Salt (NOT in marinade — salt the meat)	—	

BLOOM

Non-negotiable — fat carries aromatics into the meat

- 1

Warm oil/lard to **250–300°F** — shimmering, not smoking (below olive oil's ~400°F smoke point).
- 2

Add **cumin**, stir **30–45 sec** to nutty/fragrant — burns fast, kill heat when aromatic.
- 3

Off heat: oregano, pepper, bay. Stir residual heat **15–30 sec**. Cool 5 min. (no fresh garlic — Badia is already garlic-heavy)

COMBINE & MARINATE

- 5

Non-reactive container (never aluminum): Badia + bloomed mix + onion + Maggi. Whisk hard; it separates into fat/water phases, normal. (no salt — the marinade becomes the reduction; salt the meat directly instead)
- 6

Butt into a **4qt Cambro**, pour over to **submerge** (~1.5L covers a 6 lb butt in this vessel). Fridge **24–48 hr**; one flip at 12 hr for the fat-line surface.
- 7

6 lb: 24 hr sufficient, 48 hr max. Don't exceed — surface goes mealy.

Why bloom is mandatory: fat drives cumin/oregano warmth *into* the meat. Skip it and aromatics sit on the surface and wash off.

TEMP TARGETS

this stage — bloom & marinate

Bloom fat	250–300°F — shimmering, not smoking. Cumin scorches in seconds; kill heat the moment it's fragrant.
Marinate	Fridge 38–40°F, 24–48 hr (24 sufficient, 48 max — past that the surface goes mealy).

Cook & Pan Reduction

PART 3A

COOK

Stainless pan only — never nonstick with acid at temp

Oven, fat cap up, rack over a stainless pan	275°F
Salt the butt directly before roasting (marinade has none)	—
Marinade goes IN the pan , butt on the rack above — drippings fall in, onion cooks down	~1.5L
Top with water if the pan reduces low / threatens to scorch	—
Pull at internal	195°F
Rest, tented	45–60 min
Total estimate (stall-dependent)	~6–8 hr

Foil by bark, not clock: roast **open** until the bark is **dry, deeply colored, firm** — **doesn't smear** (~few hours). THEN foil to protect it through the stall and finish. **Tent the edges** specifically if they run ahead. Burnt edges → bitter bits in the drippings, which become the sauce — protect them.

PART 3B

PAN REDUCTION

The marinade reduced — this IS the finishing sauce

No separate mojo build — the bloomed aromatics already rode the marinade into the pan and cooked down with the drippings. Pour **pan liquid + drippings** into a pot and finish:

- 1 Hard rolling boil** first — mandatory, the marinade was raw-pork-contaminated. Not a gentle simmer.
- 2 Reduce to coats-the-spoon** (nappe) — but keep **enough volume to hold the sliced pork**. Make extra; reduce less far if you're running short. Taste for salt; cut with water/unsalted stock if it sharpens.
- 3 No finishing citrus** — the reduced Badia carries plenty of acid. Optional: a squeeze of fresh lime off-heat *only* if it tastes flat/dull (brightness, not more sour).
- 4 Hold the sliced pork in the warm sauce** — let it drink it up before building. This is the step that makes it next-level; make enough sauce to do it.

Body & tuning: if it won't reach nappe before salting out, thicken with a **cornstarch slurry** (gentle simmer, don't hard-boil after — acid breaks it). Too acidic → pinch sugar or ~0.6g baking soda at a time. Fat stays in — it rounds the acid and carries flavor.

TEMP TARGETS

this stage — roast & reduce

Roast	Oven 275°F , fat cap up. Foil by bark-set, not clock.
Pull	Pork internal 195°F , then rest tented 45–60 min.
Reduce	Hard rolling boil first (safety), then reduce to nappe — keep volume to soak the slices.

Build & Press

PART 4 BUILD bottom → top

- 1 Cuban loaf, split
- 2 Yellow mustard, **both** inside faces
- 3 Swiss (bottom — glue)
- 4 Roast pork (soaked in the warm reduction) + spoon extra sauce
- 5 Ham (ruffled)
- 6 Dill pickle planks
- 7 Swiss (top)
- 8 Top bread; **butter both outside faces**

PRESS

- Blackstone flat-top, IR-gun an even zone to **275–300°F**
- Second griddle/pan on top as the weight, compress to $\frac{1}{3}$ height
- Per side — cheese melted **and** bread crisp-golden **~4–5 min**
- Slice on the diagonal **serve hot**

Why 275–300°F, not 400°+: the press is a dual-target — bread crisps fast, cheese melts slow. Too hot = scorched crust, cold cheese. Low and patient lets heat reach the center before the bread burns. **IR-gun the surface** — a flat-top has zones; find the even one and re-check between sandwiches as it drifts.

One-lard system: the same rendered lard goes in the bread dough, brushes the crust, and fries the pork aromatics — one ingredient ties the sandwich together.

KEY PRINCIPLES hard-won — the "why"

Bread: AP, not high-gluten	Tender crumb that compresses in the press. High-gluten bakes tough and rubbery. Pale, thin crust — don't bake dark.
Flood the pan WITH the built marinade	Reverses old advice: the v1 failure was flooding with <i>pure-acid</i> marinade. This marinade has a bloomed savory base — in the pan it catches drippings and reduces into the sauce. Top with water if it scorches.
One aromatic build, at the source	The bloomed cumin/oregano in the marinade carries through to the reduction — no second mojo build needed. The marinade onion cooks down in the pan for umami.
Reduced Badia carries the acid	No finishing citrus needed — the base is heavily acidic and concentrates. Optional squeeze only if the sauce tastes flat/dull, for brightness not sour.
Stainless, never nonstick	At roasting temps/durations with acid, nonstick is out.